

THE MCKINSEY WAY

The book finishes with a chapter titled “The Most Valuable Lesson”, and proceeds to quote various ex-McKinsey-ites’ most valuable lessons. This is interesting if you’ve read the whole book, but as this is a synthesis my most valuable lesson is going to be the compilation of the most important things I’ve read in the book.

McKinsey is not a conventional consulting firm. Most consulting firms help other firms solve problems that require knowledge they possess and the client doesn’t. For example, you can call Accenture for help, and they’ll set up a new ERP for you and teach your team how to use it. This is not the case for McKinsey: they solve the problems that nobody knows how to solve. A newly recruited analyst won’t know more about petrochemicals than a manager at Chevron who has worked there for 25+ years, but somehow, he can solve the problem the manager can’t. This is due to various reasons, discussed in the following paragraphs.

Structured thinking, probably combined with analytical skill, is what makes McKinsey-ites peculiar. They live by MECE (Mutually Exclusive, Collectively Exhaustive): they break down big tasks into smaller ones in a MECE-structured way. Solving those smaller problems is easier than taking on the whole task at the same time. They come up with a hypothesis that may suit the problem, and after tedious and thorough analysis they validate and make it concrete. Normally, business problems resemble one another, so they can get inspiration from previously solved similar problems in the firm’s internal information. If this is not the case, brainstorming is the way to go, but you must be prepared before starting the brainstorming session; you should not expect to come up with a solution thanks to your genius alone. As a founder I know and admire says, “Ideas start with a blank sheet of paper and a pencil in front of you”, and this is very true: evolution has made humans visual learners; for centuries letters didn’t exist, but sketches did.

Another thing that stands out is the amount of help consultants get. They are the best guys with the best tools. It reminds me of the US Army: you may think the whole army is frontline (or that the whole firm is consultants), but the tooth-to-tail ratio in modern armies is 10%–20% to 80%–90%. McKinsey’s back and mid office is top-notch: they get PhDs, experts and researchers to produce internal information and analysis, so the consultants get better access to information than anybody else does. That, combined with all the public information and the expertise of former McKinsey-ites, makes McKinsey the best-informed consultant army. And we must not forget they get the best secretaries.

As with the way of thinking, everything at McKinsey is standardized: how to take notes after a brainstorming session, how to deal with client-side profiles that make your work difficult based on their attitude, or even how to conduct an interview. One example of this is that they strongly recommend sending a thank-you note to the people you've interviewed, as it may make somebody's day, or week. As other examples, you also get a list of what you should pack in your backpack/trolley or what activities can suit your needs when abroad. This, mixed with a very strong company culture ("the Firm"), channels everyone's efforts in the same direction: everyone is aligned with the objectives and there is minimal friction.

The work at the firm is very demanding, around 80+ hours a week, but there are some things you should remember in order to stay sane. Maximizing the energy and maintaining high levels of work for extended periods of time contributes to making these consultants the only ones capable of solving some of the hardest business problems. If your employees have much higher endurance, you are in a much better position when it comes to solving problems. One of the things McKinsey-ites do is "team building", but they don't do it in excess. The little free time you have, which is going to be scarce, you should spend with your family and friends, not on some activity with your work partners, with whom you stay at the office all day long. You are going to be fine with them anyway: you have many work dinners and plenty of time together. Another thing is that you get assigned a mentor at the firm, who is like your father inside the firm. You should go ask him if you don't know how to get something done. And the last thing worth mentioning is to have a no-work day, for example Sundays, and get away from work, relax, and put your mind at ease.

This short read took me around one week, and I think it's worth the time. I found it very light and amusing, so even if you don't plan on working at McKinsey, or even in consulting, you should read it in order to get some insight into how to solve problems effectively. And you'll get bonus knowledge on other important skills almost everyone should develop.

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